About Validation Purpose & Scope Standard

Defining Why Validation Is Required and What It Must Cover

Knowing what is being validated is not enough.

Validation must also have a purpose.

Its scope must be defined.

Its depth must be justified.

Its applicability must be understood.

Its limitations must remain visible.

Validation Purpose & Scope Standard (VPSS) is the second Parent Standard of **VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture,** governing how an established Validation Object receives a formally defined validation purpose, scope, depth, applicability, and set of limitations before validation criteria and methodology are established.

VPSS addresses one fundamental question: **Why is validation required, what must it cover, to what depth must it proceed, and within which limits may its results apply?**

Why Validation Purpose & Scope Standard Exists

A Validation Object may be precisely established while the validation itself remains poorly defined.

The same AI model may be validated for safety, regulatory compliance, operational deployment, a specific decision environment, or a limited research purpose.

The same dataset may require different validation depending on how it will be used.

The same system may require substantially different validation depth in a low-impact environment than in critical infrastructure.

Without an explicit purpose and scope, a validation process may produce a technically credible result that does not answer the question for which validation was actually required.

VPSS prevents this by establishing a governed **Validation Mandate** before subsequent validation activities proceed.

Purpose Before Criteria

Validation criteria should not be selected without knowing what validation is intended to establish.

Validation methodology should not be chosen without understanding the required scope.

Validation depth should not be determined independently of intended use.

Validation conclusions should not be interpreted beyond the applicability for which validation was performed.

VPSS therefore establishes the progression:

Validation Object → Validation Purpose → Validation Scope → Validation Depth → Validation Applicability → Validation Limitations → Validation Mandate

This mandate becomes the governance reference for subsequent VALIDOS® activities.

Purpose and Scope Are Different

Purpose and scope perform different governance functions.

Validation Purpose answers:

Why are we validating this object?

Validation Scope answers:

Which aspects of the object must validation examine?

A validation may have a legitimate purpose but an insufficient scope.

It may also have a broad scope that is unnecessary for the actual purpose.

VPSS requires these two dimensions to remain aligned.

Object Boundary Is Not Validation Scope

VALIDOS® makes another important distinction.

Validation Object Boundary determines what the object is.

Validation Scope determines which aspects of that object are being examined.

An AI system may contain ten components within its established object boundary while a particular validation examines only three of them.

A dataset may contain many variables while validation addresses only those relevant to a specific intended use.

A process may contain multiple operational stages while validation concerns only one defined decision pathway.

This distinction prevents a validation result from being interpreted as covering the complete object merely because the entire object has been identified.

Validation Depth Must Be Proportionate

Not every validation requires the same level of examination.

A low-impact internal analytical tool and a system controlling critical infrastructure should not automatically require identical validation depth.

VPSS therefore treats validation depth as a governed decision.

Relevant considerations may include:

- intended use,
- operational significance,
- complexity,
- uncertainty,
- potential consequences,
- dependency exposure,
- reversibility,
- regulatory requirements,
- governance requirements,
- and risk.

The objective is neither minimum validation nor maximum validation.

The objective is **proportionate validation** capable of supporting the stated purpose.

Applicability Defines Where Validation Travels

A validation result should not automatically travel everywhere the Validation Object travels.

A validation performed for one:

- use case,
- environment,
- jurisdiction,
- population,
- deployment configuration,
- operational condition,
- decision type,
- or time period

may not support another.

VPSS establishes the applicability conditions that determine where the resulting validation may legitimately be interpreted and used.

This creates a critical governance distinction:

Validated does not mean universally validated.

Limitations Must Remain Visible

Validation may proceed despite limitations.

The existence of a limitation does not automatically make validation invalid.

However, limitations must remain visible because they affect what the resulting determination can legitimately support.

Examples may include:

- excluded characteristics,
- inaccessible information,
- unavailable populations,
- restricted environments,
- incomplete historical data,
- unresolved dependencies,
- temporal restrictions,
- or methodological constraints.

VPSS converts these limitations from hidden uncertainty into explicit governance information.

Scope Change Must Be Governed

Validation does not always remain static.

During validation:

- the objective may change,
- additional use cases may be introduced,
- scope may expand,
- exclusions may be removed,
- required depth may increase,
- or intended reliance may become more significant.

VPSS requires material changes to be recognized rather than silently absorbed into the existing validation process.

A material change may require reconsideration of subsequent:

Criteria → Method → Evidence → Sources → Execution → Determination

This preserves methodological continuity across the validation lifecycle.

The Validation Mandate

The primary governance result of VPSS is the establishment of a **Validation Mandate.**

The Validation Mandate connects:

Object + Purpose + Scope + Depth + Applicability + Limitations

It provides a governed reference describing what the validation process is expected to accomplish and the conditions under which its eventual determination may be interpreted.

The mandate therefore becomes a bridge between the Validation Object established under VOBS and the Validation Criteria established in the next VALIDOS® governance space.

Governance Rather Than Technical Testing

VPSS does not prescribe laboratory tests, software-testing procedures, statistical techniques, model benchmarks, verification technologies, or implementation-specific validation mechanisms.

Those mechanisms may later support validation.

VPSS governs the conditions that must be established **before those mechanisms are selected and applied.**

This allows VALIDOS® to remain technology-neutral while supporting different industries, systems, validation methodologies, and future operational environments.

Position Within VALIDOS®

Validation Purpose & Scope Standard is the second Parent Standard of **VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture.**

It follows:

Validation Object Standard (VOBS)

and precedes the establishment of formal validation criteria.

Its architectural position is:

Validation Object → Validation Purpose & Scope → Validation Criteria → Validation Method → Validation Evidence Fitness → Validation Source Reliability → Validation Execution → Validation Determination

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→ Validation State → Validation Reliance & Revalidation

VOBS establishes:

What exactly are we validating?

VPSS establishes:

Why are we validating it, what must validation cover, and within which limits may the result apply?

The next governance space can then determine:

Against what conditions should validity be judged?

Relationship to Other OOF® Architectures

VPSS operates alongside complementary OOF® governance architectures.

GOA™ may establish governance authority, organizational scope, boundaries, and delegation.

RIS™ may provide risk information relevant to validation depth and proportionality.

ORA™ may establish operational environments and operational conditions relevant to validation applicability.

OBIDENITY® may provide identity, ownership, provenance, authority, and continuity information.

INTEGROS® may provide integrity conditions relevant to validation objectives.

AGA™ may establish accountability and responsibility relationships affecting the validation mandate.

VPSS does not reproduce these governance responsibilities.

It translates relevant governed requirements into a validation-specific purpose, scope, depth, applicability, and limitation structure.

Why It Matters

A validation can be methodologically rigorous and still be unsuitable for the purpose for which someone later relies upon it.

A narrowly validated model may be deployed broadly.

A validation conducted in one environment may be assumed to apply in another.

A limited evaluation may be presented as comprehensive validation.

A low-depth validation may become the basis for a high-consequence decision.

VPSS creates the governance structure necessary to prevent these mismatches.

It ensures that validation answers not only:

Was something validated?

but also:

Why, how broadly, how deeply, and for what legitimate use?

Foundational Principle

Validation can support only the purpose and scope it was designed to examine.

Canonical Closing Statement

Validation Purpose & Scope Standard establishes the mandate layer of VALIDOS® — Validation Governance Architecture. By governing validation purpose, scope, depth, applicability, limitations, proportionality, and material scope change, VPSS ensures that validation is designed around an explicit governance need and that its eventual determinations cannot legitimately be extended beyond the conditions they were established to examine.

Parent Resources

→ VALIDOS® Architecture Map

→ VALIDOS® Complete Standards & Modules Index

Related Documents

→ Validation Purpose & Scope Standard

→ VALIDOS® Validation Governance Architecture — Validation Governance Layer

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